THE ELECTORAL REFORM SOCIETY OF SOUTH AUSTRALIA

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Inquiry into the 2025 Federal Election

The 2025 Federal Election was held on May 3, 2025, for the 150 single-member electorates in the House of Assembly and 40 members of the Senate.

In summary, the final results were –

House of Representatives (150 single-member)			**Senate** (6 6-member & 2 2-member, PR)	
	Votes	**Seats**	**Votes**	**Seats**
ALP	35%	63% (94 seats)	35%	40% (16 Senators)
Coalition	32%	29% (43)	30%	33% (13)
Greens	12%	1% (1)	12%	15% (6)
One Nation	6%	0	6%	8% (3)
Independents	7%	7% (10)		
Other	8%	1% (2)	17%	4% (2)

In terms of fairness, the Senate elected using proportional representation provides a much better result in reflecting the voters' will when the whole country is considered. For the House of Representatives, the main reason for the distortion in how electors voted was due to the single-member electoral system.

The Electoral Reform Society of South Australia recommends that the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters consider whether the House of Representatives should be elected by the quota-preferential method of proportional representation with Australia divided into multi-member electorates.

Inquiry's Terms of Reference

Several of the terms of reference deal with the possibility of disruptive behaviour and attempts to obstruct the electoral process, either foreign or domestic. While the Electoral Reform Society is not aware of any issues within South Australia which raised concerns at this year's election***, it is essential that the integrity of Australia's electoral procedure is not only maintained but strengthened.***

Within this submission, the Electoral Reform Society wishes to address the following two terms of reference:

- *the suitability and potential reform of measures to ensure universal voter access, including polling booth availability and location, early voting, remote polling, and postal voting arrangements; and*

- *the composition of the Parliament as a whole, including: the length of the parliamentary term; the potential for fixed terms; and the number of elected representatives relative to the growth in population and the electorate.*

In relation to the first term of reference listed, there is an increasing trend towards early voting. To cater for this trend, ***consideration needs to be given to increasing the number of places where early voting can take place.***

As Australia's postal system continues to deteriorate, this will make it more difficult to facilitate postal voting and potentially hinders universal voter access. ***Consideration needs to be given to allowing on-line voting as an alternative where it is difficult for electors to physically attend a polling place.***

Following a recent change in South Australia, the 2025 Federal election was the first where the displaying of corflutes on roadsides and on other public property was banned. The Society was concerned that for some electors, the use of corflutes was the only way they knew that there was an election on.

It appears our concerns were unfounded, perhaps as there were more corflutes on display on private property.

In contrast to the restriction on the use of corflutes during the election campaign, there was an extreme overuse of corflutes and other election banners at polling places on election day. As some electors found this very daunting, ***there now needs to be a restriction on the number of banners and other election material at polling place. Even a ban on canvassing a couple of days before election day could be considered.***

In relation to the second term of refence –

the composition of the Parliament as a whole, including: the length of the parliamentary term; the potential for fixed terms; and the number of elected representatives relative to the growth in population and the electorate.

The Electoral Reform Society of South Australia supports fixed parliamentary terms. Fixed terms remove the uncertainty of when the next election will be called. This means the government of the day is not able to take advantages from springing an election when it suited them. It will result in a more level playing field for all political parties and candidates, and indeed for the electors. Having a fixed date would also allow the Australian Electoral Commission to be better prepared in advance for running each election.

If the length of the parliamentary term for the House of Representatives was increased, perhaps to four years, this would mean a consequential eight- years for the Senate which for many is considered far too long.

While the House of Representatives consists of single-member electorates, there is not a suitable method of replacing early retiring members without by-elections. ***The Electoral Reform Society of South Australia supports proportional representation, which allows recounts to be used to ensure that the wishes of the electors as indicated at the last general election would be maintained.*** Recounts are successfully used for the Tasmanian House of Assembly whenever there is a retiring member.

As the population of Australia has significantly increased since the last change in the number of MPs and Senators in the Australian Parliament, ***there is now an urgent need to consider increasing the representation.***

Other issues

There are several other issues that the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters should consider in relation to the 2025 Federal election, dealing with providing information to voters, as well as some aspects in electing the House of Representatives and the Senate.

- *Information to voters*

  The "Your official guide" delivered to all households by the Australian Electoral Commission is too generic and hence too vague. ***There is a need for a guide to be provided for each electorate which could include a list of polling places, and the list of candidates*** (as well as some details on each of these, including where to obtain more information). As example, in South Australia it was very difficult to find out details about the Senate candidates, particularly for the ALP.

  As an alternative to the printed guide, perhaps a short summary from each candidate presented to the electoral office could be made available via the internet.

- *House of Representatives*

  While members of the House of Representatives continue to be elected from single-member electorates, this can at times mean that the order of the candidates on the ballot paper will influence the result. ***To overcome the effect of the donkey vote, consideration needs to be given to using the Robson rotation so that no one candidate receives an unfair advantage from the position on the ballot paper.***

  At the moment a candidate for the House of Representatives needs to obtain at least a 4% threshold of votes to keep their nomination fee and to receive public funding. While the Electoral Reform Society argues against even having a threshold figure (as it implies that not all votes are equal), ***if there must be a threshold figure it needs to be flexible*** as the vote received by each candidate can be dependent on how many candidates are on the ballot paper.

  It was concerning at the 2025 Federal election, that where there was the necessity for checking and recounting the votes, that the level of inaccuracies was in some instances inexplicitly high in the initial counts. While the final counts were accurate, that such errors were even happening is worrying.

- *Senate*

The previous Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters in its Report on the conduct of the 2016 Federal election made as its first recommendation that:

> **"The Committee recommends that the Australian Government commission a technical report on the most appropriate count and surplus transfer methodology for Senate elections, and**
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> **This technical report should consider the need for a progressively reducing quota."**

This recommendation still needs to be implemented, and the Electoral Reform Society urges the current Committee to follow up on this technical aspect of the Senate count.

The Society is also concerned at the design of the Senate ballot paper. Again the Robson rotation should be used for each list of candidates.

In addition the grouping of individual candidates at the end of the ballot paper needs to be questioned. Grouping for the same party is fine, but grouping individual independents can be misinterpreted as well as misleading when electors are so used to seeing parties grouped. And this is compounded by how hard it is to find information explaining the policies and attitudes of independent candidates.

The Electoral Reform Society of South Australia promotes the Hare Clark quota preferential method of proportional representation (Quota preferential is also known as single transferable vote or STV). Many electoral systems have major flaws, which can result in apparently democratic elections having very undemocratic outcomes. While no electoral system is perfect, Hare Clark is free from these major flaws and has a great deal to commend it. It is a fair and practical way to implement representative democracy in organisations ranging from small local clubs to large countries and international organisations.

For almost 100 years the Electoral Reform Society of South Australia has been committed to establishing fairer elections in South Australia, elections where voters can be assured of receiving what they voted for. To do this it is essential that we have a system of Proportional Representation using the Single Transferable Vote method for all elections.